Progress Log

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Development of a PT100-Based Digital Thermometer

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Acknowledgment

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Abstract

This log records the practical development of our PT100-based digital thermometer, from understanding the components and testing a standard character LCD to debugging the complete sensor circuit, transferring it to perfboard, and designing an enclosure in OpenSCAD. The emphasis is on the work actually carried out, including the faults encountered and the checks used to isolate them. The reference paper supplied for the project also discusses automated data collection and machine-learning calibration; our implementation instead relied on manual calibration and a direct resistance-to-temperature calculation on an Arduino.

1 Project Objective and Working Principle

Our objective was to build a compact digital thermometer using a PT100 platinum resistance temperature detector (RTD), an Arduino, and a 16-by-2 character LCD. The PT100 was selected because its resistance changes predictably with temperature and it is widely used in precision temperature measurement. Its nominal resistance is $100\,\Omega$ at $0\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$. Around ordinary operating temperatures, the resistance changes by approximately $0.385\,\Omega$ per degree Celsius, so reliable measurement requires attention to the sensing circuit, connections, and calibration.

The basic measurement chain is:

1. The PT100 resistance changes as its temperature changes.
2. A resistor-based measurement circuit converts that resistance into a voltage that the Arduino's analogue input can read.
3. The Arduino averages repeated analogue-to-digital converter (ADC) readings and estimates the sensor resistance.
4. A temperature equation converts the estimated resistance into temperature.
5. The LCD displays the calculated temperature and the compensated resistance, while the serial monitor provides additional diagnostic values.

The supplied reference material describes more elaborate alternatives, including a Wheatstone bridge, an external ADS1115 ADC, automated optical character recognition (OCR), and machine-learning regression. Those methods were useful background, but they were not the calibration workflow we followed for this build. Our practical focus was to make the physical circuit reliable and to calibrate it manually.

2 Components and Circuit Understanding

We began by identifying the components and understanding the role of each part before making permanent connections. The main components were the Arduino board, PT100 sensor, reference resistor, 16-by-2 parallel LCD, contrast potentiometer, breadboard, jumper wires, and later a perfboard for the permanent circuit. The potentiometer adjusts the LCD contrast; it does not perform the temperature calibration.

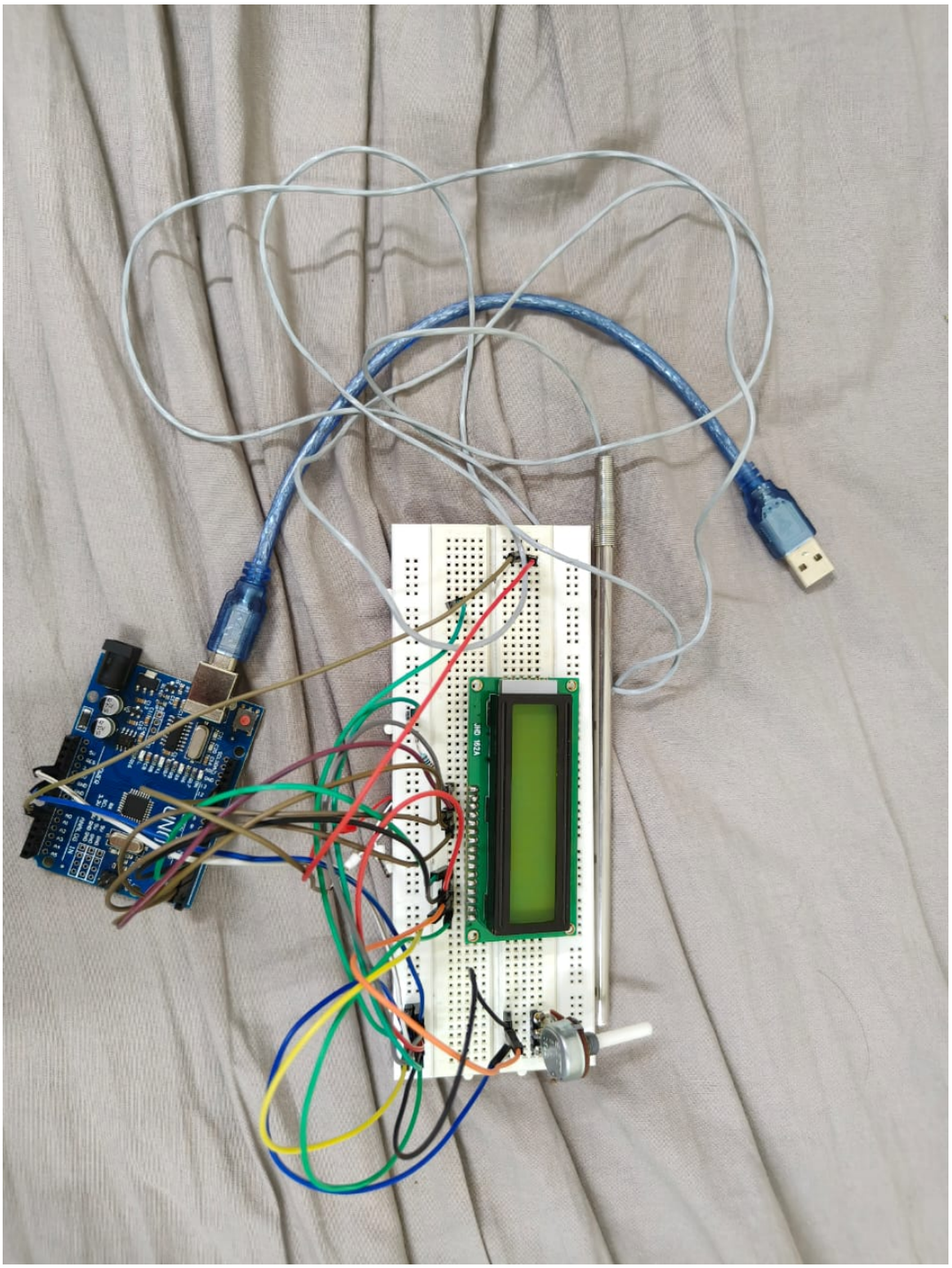


Figure 1: Components collected for the PT100 thermometer.

We studied the circuit schematic provided with the reference material to understand the sensor measurement path and the display connections. The sensor circuit and the LCD circuit have different jobs: the sensor path provides a measurable voltage related to resistance, while the LCD path presents the result to the user. A common ground and correct supply connections are essential for both sections to work consistently.

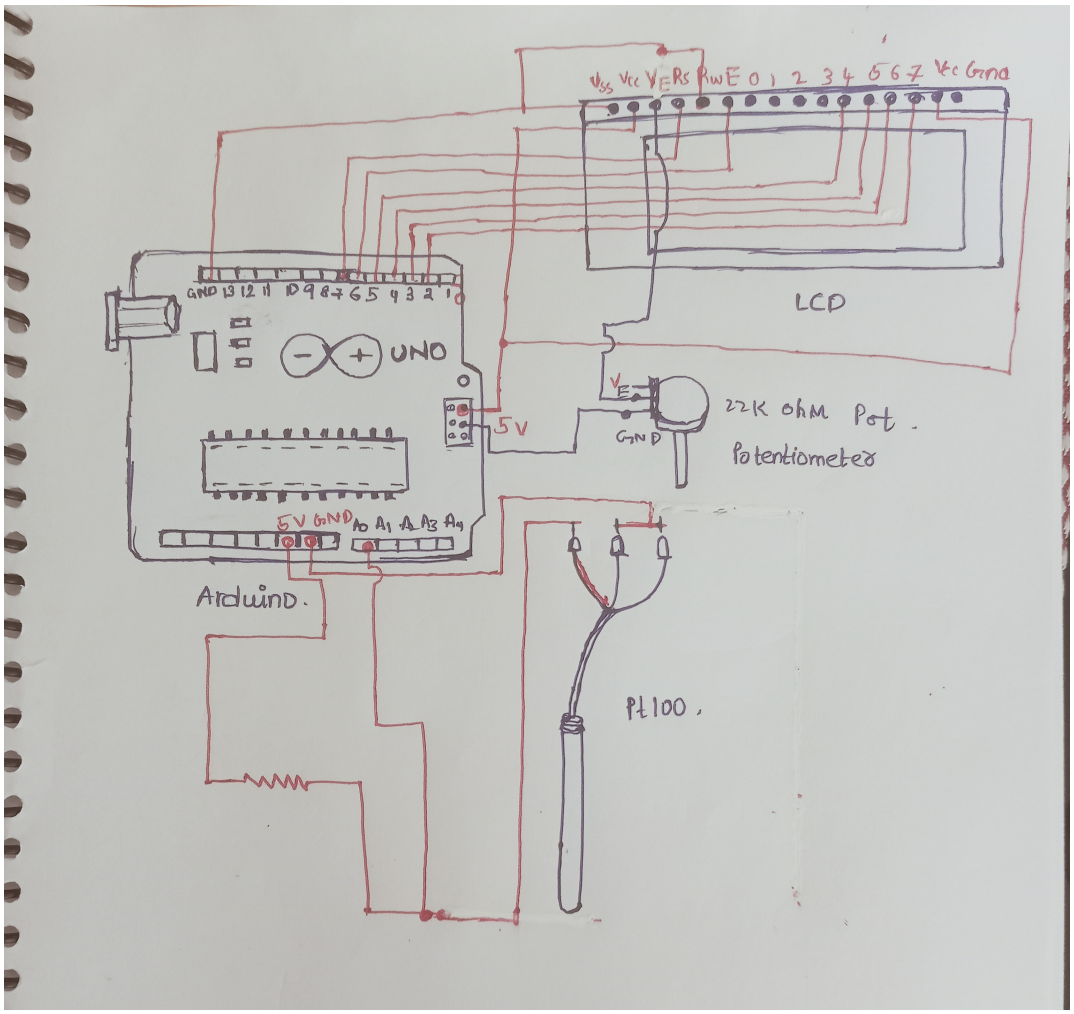


Figure 2: Reference schematic used to understand the measurement and display circuits.

A key concept was that the Arduino does not measure resistance directly. It measures voltage at an analogue input. Resistance is inferred from the voltage-divider relationship and the known reference resistance (with a reference resistance of approximately 120 Ω). Any unexpected series resistance from leads, jumper wires, or contacts can therefore affect the result. This became especially relevant during debugging and calibration.

3 Testing the LCD

Before connecting the PT100 measurement circuit, we tested the LCD as a separate subsystem. We wired the standard parallel LCD directly to the Arduino, without an I^2C backpack, and used a simple test program to check whether the display could operate independently.

Our tests included:

- printing `Hello World`;
- checking whether text could scroll as expected; and

- changing the displayed text over time.

These tests were intended to separate LCD and wiring problems from any problems that might later arise in the PT100 measurement code.

3.1 Jumper wire connection issue

The LCD did not behave as expected during the first tests. We initially suspected that the Arduino or the LCD itself might be defective. After spending considerable time checking the hardware, we traced the problem to faulty jumper wires. This was an important debugging lesson: a connection that looks physically correct is not necessarily electrically continuous.

We learned to verify suspect wires individually and to change only one part of the setup at a time. Testing the LCD separately was still useful, because it established a simple baseline before we introduced the sensor and its measurement code.

4 Calibration Using Least Squares

4.1 Introduction to Calibration

Calibration is the process of establishing a mathematical relationship between the output of a measuring instrument and a corresponding reference quantity of known value. In sensor applications, calibration enables measured electrical quantities, such as voltage, to be converted into meaningful physical quantities, such as temperature.

When a sensor exhibits a nonlinear voltage–temperature relationship, a polynomial model may be used to approximate its behaviour over a specified operating range. A second-degree polynomial model is given by

$$\boxed{T = Av^2 + Bv + C}$$

where T is the reference temperature in °C, v is the measured sensor voltage in Volts (V), and A, B, and C are calibration coefficients determined experimentally. Note that our system utilizes a reference resistance of approximately $120\,\Omega$.

4.2 Experimental Data Collection

Calibration begins with the collection of experimental data where each observation pairs a sensor voltage with a reference temperature, Note that, the measured data contains 6 decimal points but the least count of ADC is not : $(v_1, T_1), \ldots, (v_N, T_N)$.

Below is a dataset for our initial calibration dataset containing roughly 7 ADC voltage and temperature measurements (note that this initial dataset led to an average error of 5–6 degrees due to calibration offsets):

Observation i	temperature v_i (V)	Voltage T_i (°C)
1	86.3	2.520586
2	71.6	2.474252
3	62.5	2.437185
4	53.6	2.404751
5	45.5	2.376950
6	34.8	2.331195
7	22.4	2.284281

Table 1: Initial Calibration Dataset (7 points, leading to 5–6°C error).

Observation i	Temperature v_i (V)	Voltage T_i (°C)
1	7.3	2.359883
2	10.8	2.374663
3	15.1	2.394369
4	20.1	2.414076
5	25.8	2.438710
6	30.2	2.458416
7	34.8	2.478123
8	39.5	2.497633
9	44.4	2.517537
10	50.5	2.542170
11	56.9	2.566803
12	60.4	2.581583
13	65.5	2.601260
14	71.1	2.620997
15	73.9	2.630850
16	79.4	2.650557
17	83.2	2.665337
18	90.3	2.689971
19	96.8	2.714604

Table 2: Final Calibration Table (19 voltages with minimal error).

4.3 Computational Method Using NumPy polyfit

In practice, manual matrix inversion and custom implementations can be streamlined using robust numerical libraries. Here, we utilize NumPy's built-in `polyfit` function to perform a 2nd-order polynomial least-squares regression directly on our calibration dataset.

The script initializes the voltage and temperature arrays, computes the coefficients for the quadratic model $T = aX^2 + bX + c$, and prints them formatted for microcontroller implementation.

Python: Polynomial Curve Fitting via NumPy polyfit

```
import numpy as np

X_data = np.array([
    2.359883, 2.374663, 2.394369, 2.414076, 2.438710,
    2.458416, 2.478123, 2.497633, 2.517537, 2.542170,
    2.566803, 2.581583, 2.601260, 2.620997, 2.630850,
    2.650557, 2.665337, 2.689971, 2.714604
])

T_data = np.array([
    7.3, 10.8, 15.1, 20.1, 25.8, 30.2, 34.8,
    39.5, 44.4, 50.5, 56.9, 60.4, 65.5, 71.1,
    73.9, 79.4, 83.2, 90.3, 96.8
])

# 2. Fit a 2nd-order polynomial (Quadratic: T = a*X^2 + b*X + c)
a, b, c = np.polyfit(X_data, T_data, 2)

print(f"const float a = {a:.8f};")
print(f"const float b = {b:.8f};")
print(f"const float c = {c:.8f};")
```

The Python calibration script is located in:

`calibration/calibration_source_code.py`

The experimental calibration dataset is stored in:

`calibration/calibration_data.dat`

The source code uploaded to the Arduino is in the following directory:

`source_code.cpp`

It is important to note that the source code implements the least squares method for the calibration through use of polyfit.

5 Checking the Completed Breadboard Circuit

After the circuit was operating, we rechecked the individual connections with a multimeter. This was not just a final formality: it helped us confirm electrical continuity and look for unexpected shorts or open connections before making the arrangement permanent.

We checked the connections methodically, including supply and ground, LCD signal wiring, the potentiometer connections, and the PT100 measurement path. We also treated the measured resistance as a useful diagnostic value. A resistance reading that was inconsistent with the expected sensor path could indicate a poor connection, a wrong connection, or a short circuit.

5.1 Troubleshooting corrupted LCD characters

After integrating the LCD, potentiometer, PT100, and Arduino, the display showed corrupted characters rather than the intended output. We checked the circuit again and found two contributing issues: some jumper wires were damaged, and the LCD data connections had been made in reverse order. Since the LCD uses several parallel data lines, incorrect ordering can produce unreadable characters even when the display is powered.

We corrected the wiring and checked the data-pin order against the connection reference. This reinforced the need to verify every signal line individually rather than relying only on the apparent neatness of the circuit.

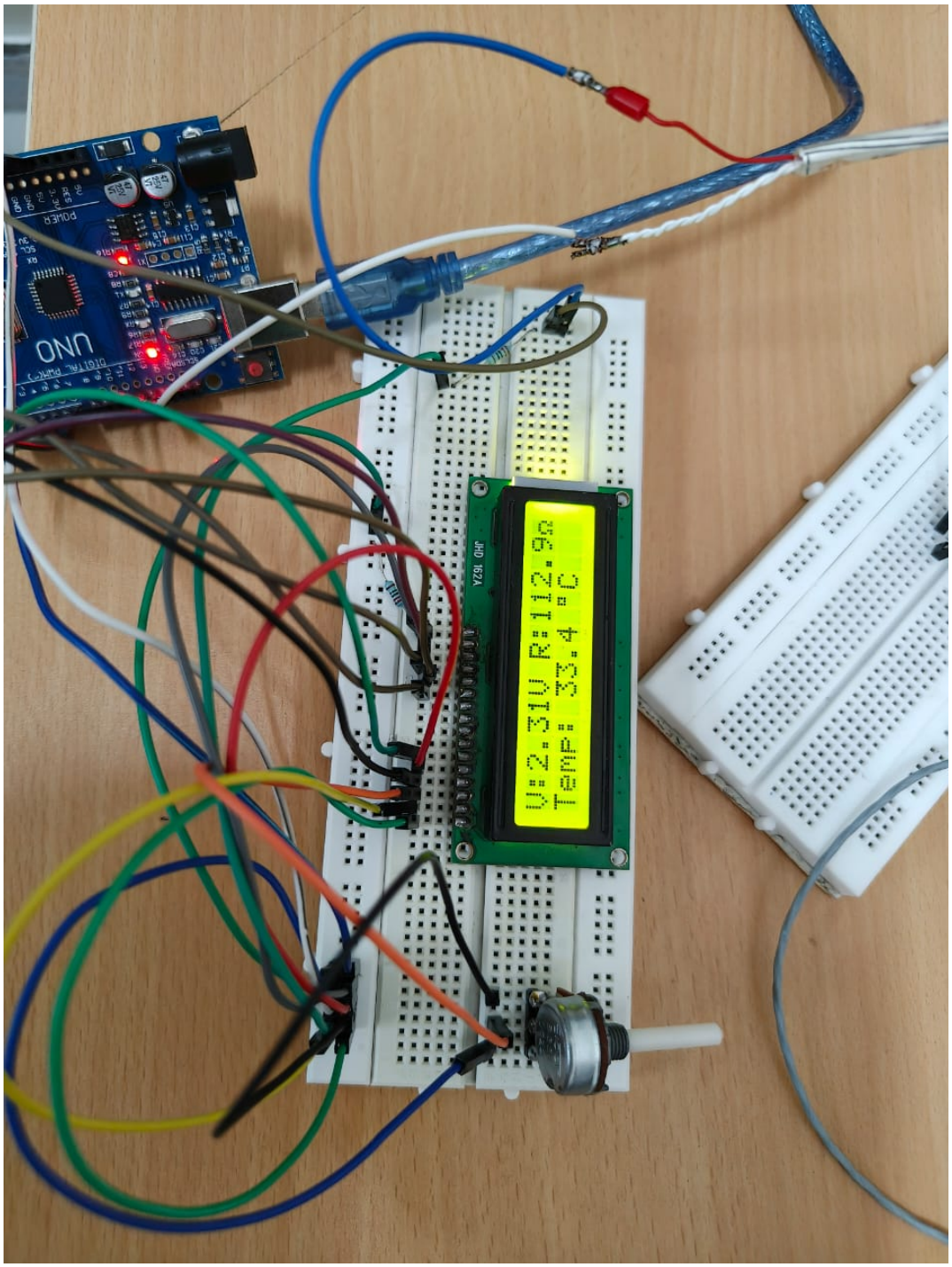


Figure 3: Integrated PT100 thermometer circuit on the breadboard after the wiring was reorganised.

Intentional pin-layout modification: we deliberately changed the LCD pin assignments from those shown in the reference PDF to create a neater and more practical physical layout. The Arduino sketch was updated to match the revised wiring. After making the changes, we checked the connections and tested the LCD signals to confirm that the pins were working as intended. We also verified the completed program's behaviour and confirmed that no callback-related errors remained at the end of testing.

This stage gave us more confidence that the circuit was not merely displaying plausible numbers by chance. It also provided a useful baseline for the transfer from breadboard to perfboard, where every connection would become harder to change.

6 Moving the Circuit to Perfboard

After verifying the breadboard circuit, we transferred the design to a perfboard. The goal was to move from temporary plug-in connections to a more compact and mechanically stable arrangement suitable for the thermometer enclosure.

We planned the component positions before completing the soldering. The layout needed to minimise occupied space while leaving enough room to route the connections clearly and avoid unintended contact between conductive points. Compactness was important, but it could not come at the cost of making the circuit difficult to inspect or repair.

We soldered the header pins such that, it fit perfectly on the arduino, creating a very compact design without use the wires. You can just pop-in the header pins directly to the arduino digital pins quite easily and without the mess of wires getting in the way.

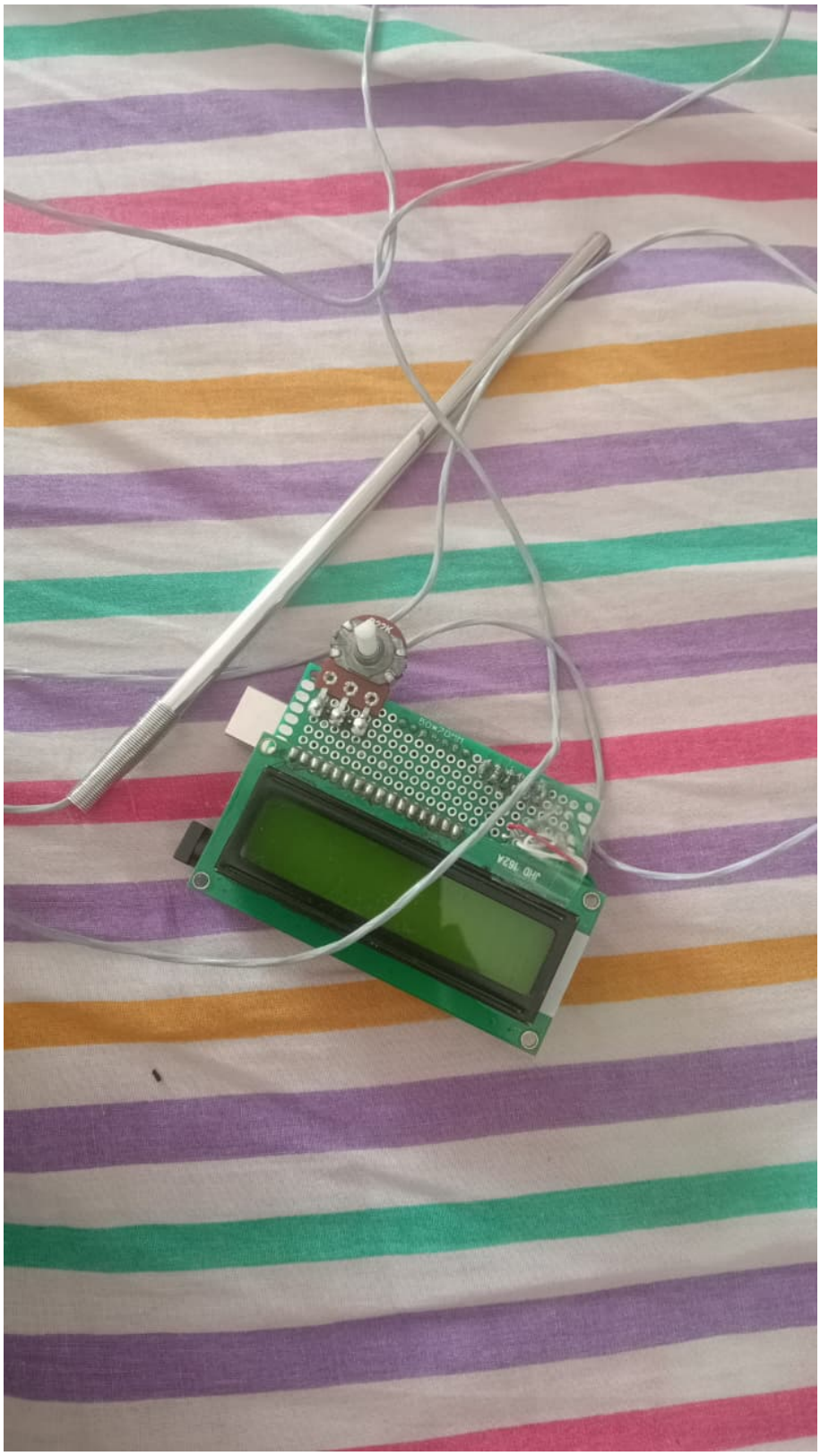


Figure 4: Compact soldered circuit

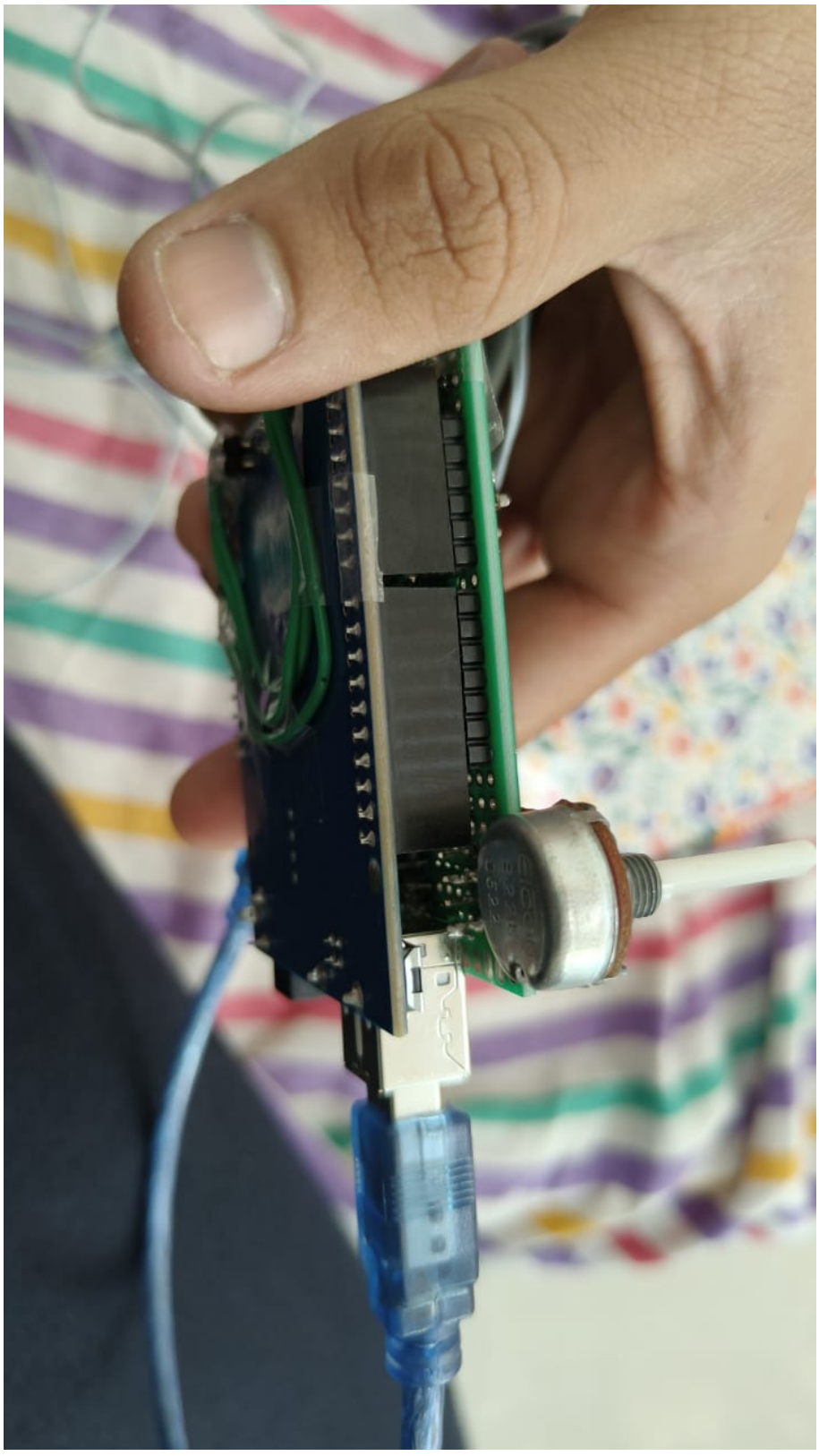


Figure 5: Sideview of soldered circuit

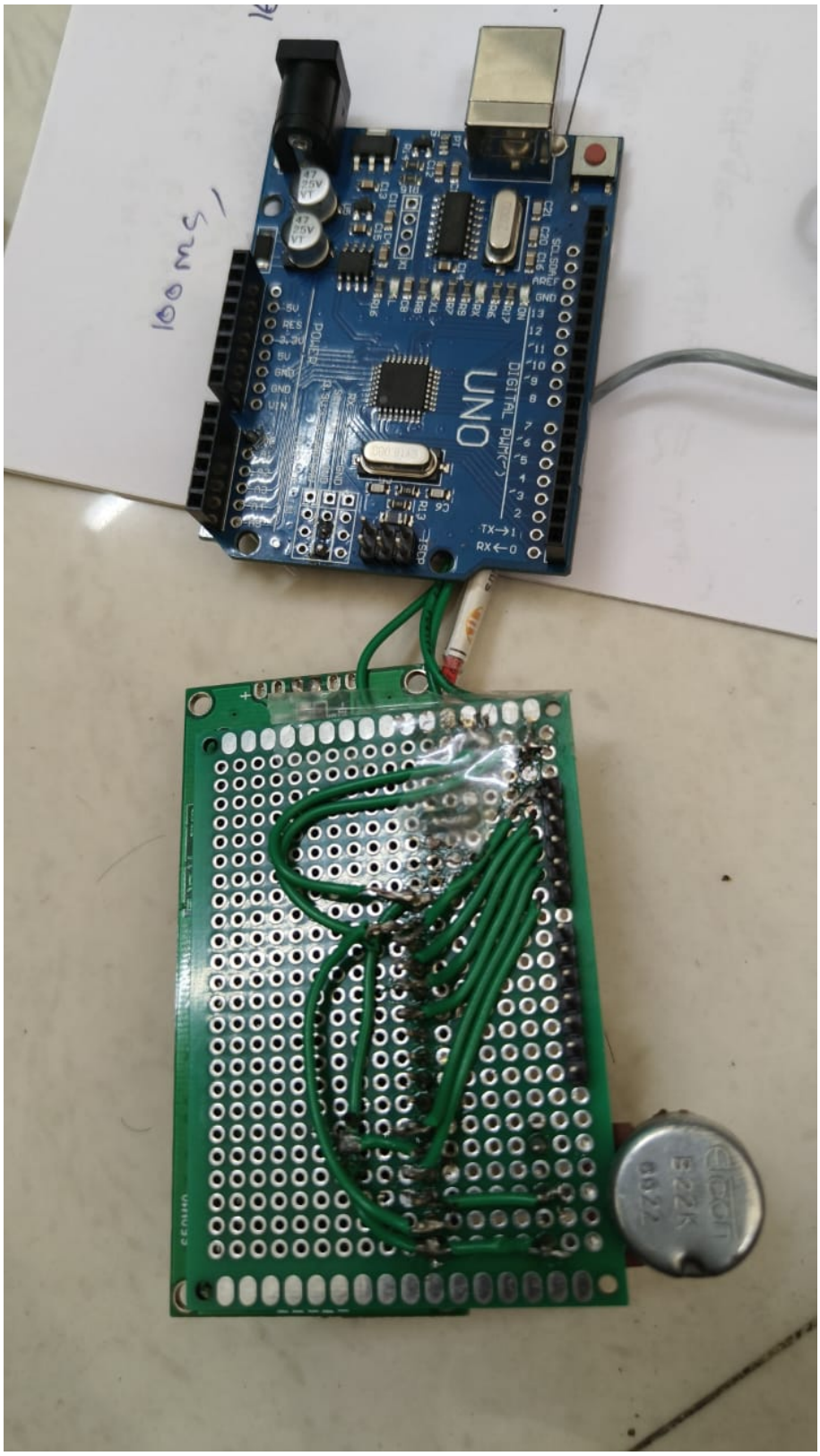


Figure 6: Disassembled arduino

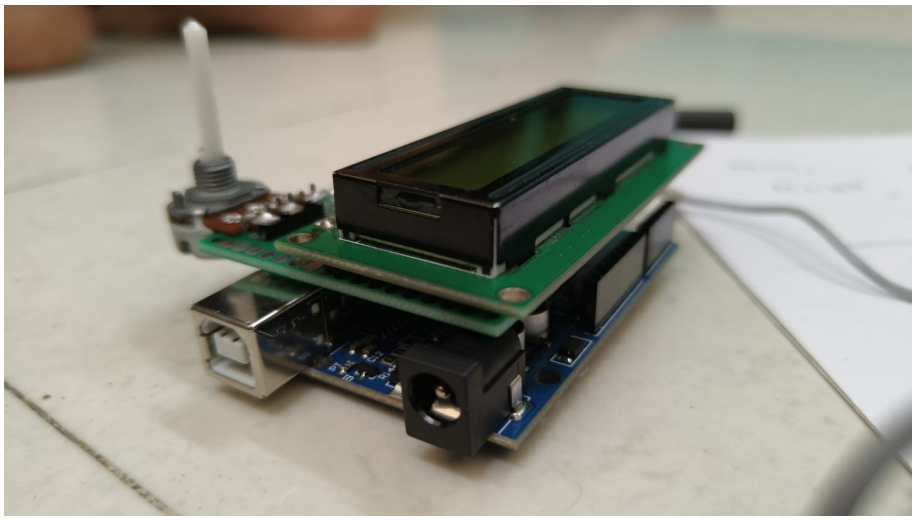


Figure 7: Soldered circuit

6.1 PT100 terminals shorted during soldering

During soldering, the PT100 terminals were accidentally shorted. The multimeter then indicated a resistance of approximately $0\,\Omega$, which was inconsistent with the nominal $100\,\Omega$ PT100 resistance at $0\,^{\circ}\mathrm{C}$. This made debugging confusing until we considered that the problem might be in the newly soldered connections rather than in the sensor or the software.

The incident demonstrated why continuity and resistance checks are necessary after soldering. A solder bridge can bypass the sensing element and make the circuit appear to have almost no resistance. The appropriate response is to disconnect power, inspect the solder joints, remove any unintended bridge, and measure the isolated sensor path again before reconnecting the circuit.

We used this experience to reinforce our practice of checking the physical circuit after each significant change instead of assuming that a circuit which worked on a breadboard will remain correct after soldering.

7 Enclosure Design in OpenSCAD

Once the circuit had been transferred to perfboard, we designed and modelled an enclosure in OpenSCAD. The aim was to give the electronics a defined physical form, protect the assembled circuit during ordinary handling, and make the LCD readable from the front.

The model allowed us to consider the relationship between the board, display, wiring space, and external dimensions before fabricating a case. We treated the enclosure as part of the engineering process rather than as decoration: a useful case must accommodate the real component dimensions and allow access to the display without placing pressure on the solder joints or wires.

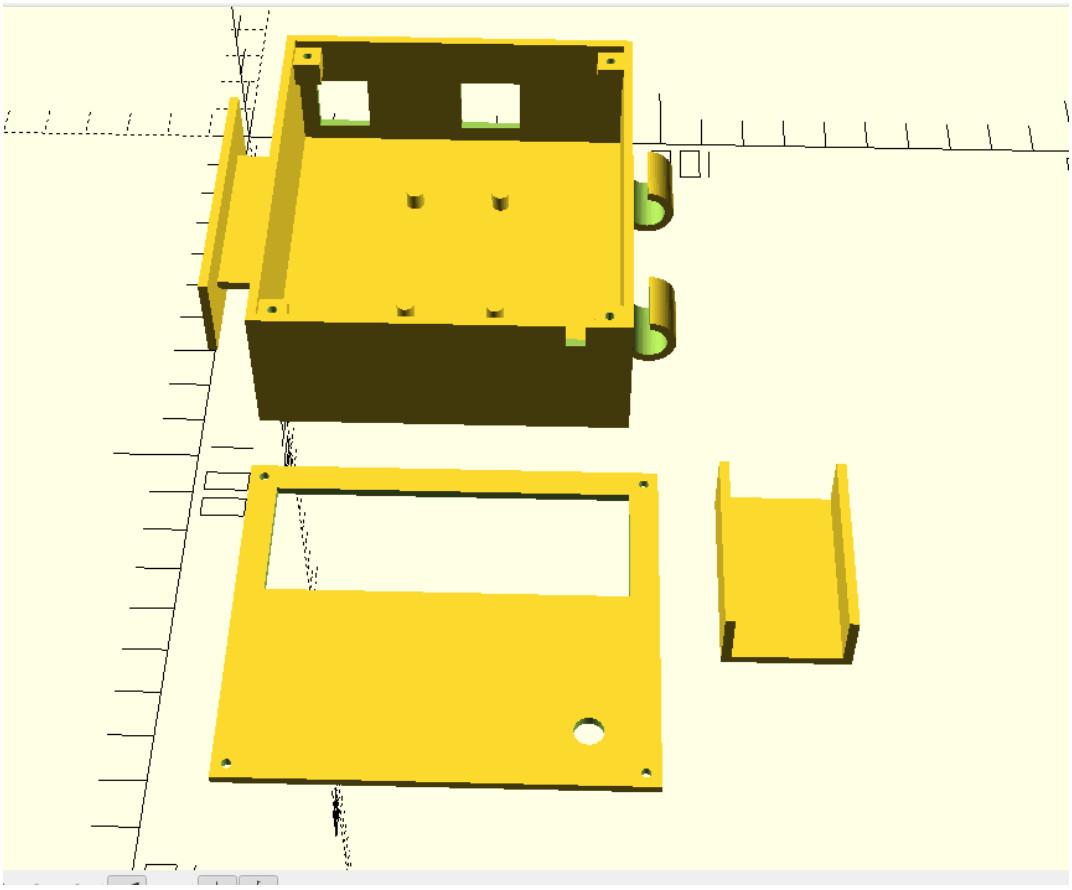


Figure 8: View of the enclosure model, used to inspect its overall form and layout.

The modelling stage also made us think about maintainability. A compact case is valuable only if the circuit can still be assembled, inspected, and serviced. The final dimensions should therefore be checked against the actual perfboard, LCD, and cable positions before fabrication.

8 Calibration, Verification, and Practical Limitations

Calibration was performed manually rather than through the automated OCR and machine-learning pipeline described in the reference paper. The generic PT100 least-squares coefficient method initially led to a noticeable temperature error of 5–6 degrees Celsius. Upon investigation, we discovered that the reference voltage was initially assumed to be 4.7 V, whereas the actual supply voltage measured directly was 5 V—an error attributed to a faulty multimeter during preliminary checks.

To rectify this and achieve high precision, we performed a refined final calibration using an expanded dataset of 19 voltage measurements with minimal error. Below is the placeholder for our final calibration dataset table:

The reference material explains why calibration matters: the PT100's resistance-temperature relation is predictable but not perfectly linear, and small resistance errors can produce noticeable temperature errors.

In our implementation, calibration involved checking the displayed temperature against a reference thermometer at known or observed temperatures and adjusting the relevant software parameters as required. The code contains a reference-resistance value and a lead/contact correction, so those values must correspond to the assembled hardware. A calibration result is meaningful only when the sensor and reference thermometer have had time to approach the same temperature and the measurements are taken consistently.

The uploaded sketch averages 19 ADC readings to reduce short-term measurement jitter. Averaging can make a reading steadier, but it does not by itself remove systematic errors caused by a wrong resistance value, poor connections, supply variation, sensor placement, or insufficient calibration. Likewise, a stable LCD reading is not proof of industrial-grade accuracy. Accuracy must be established by repeated comparison with a suitable reference over the intended operating range.

We have calibrated from 0-100 degree celsius. To have accurate measurment beyond this range requires further calibration. In view of this, the data sockets of arduino have been left exposed for easy access to potential developments.

8.1 Project Demonstration

After tedious verification and calibration, our project was finally completed. Given below are four demonstrations of our thermometer alongside, laboratory grade thermometer.



Figure 9: Project demonstration 1 alongside laboratory-grade thermometer.

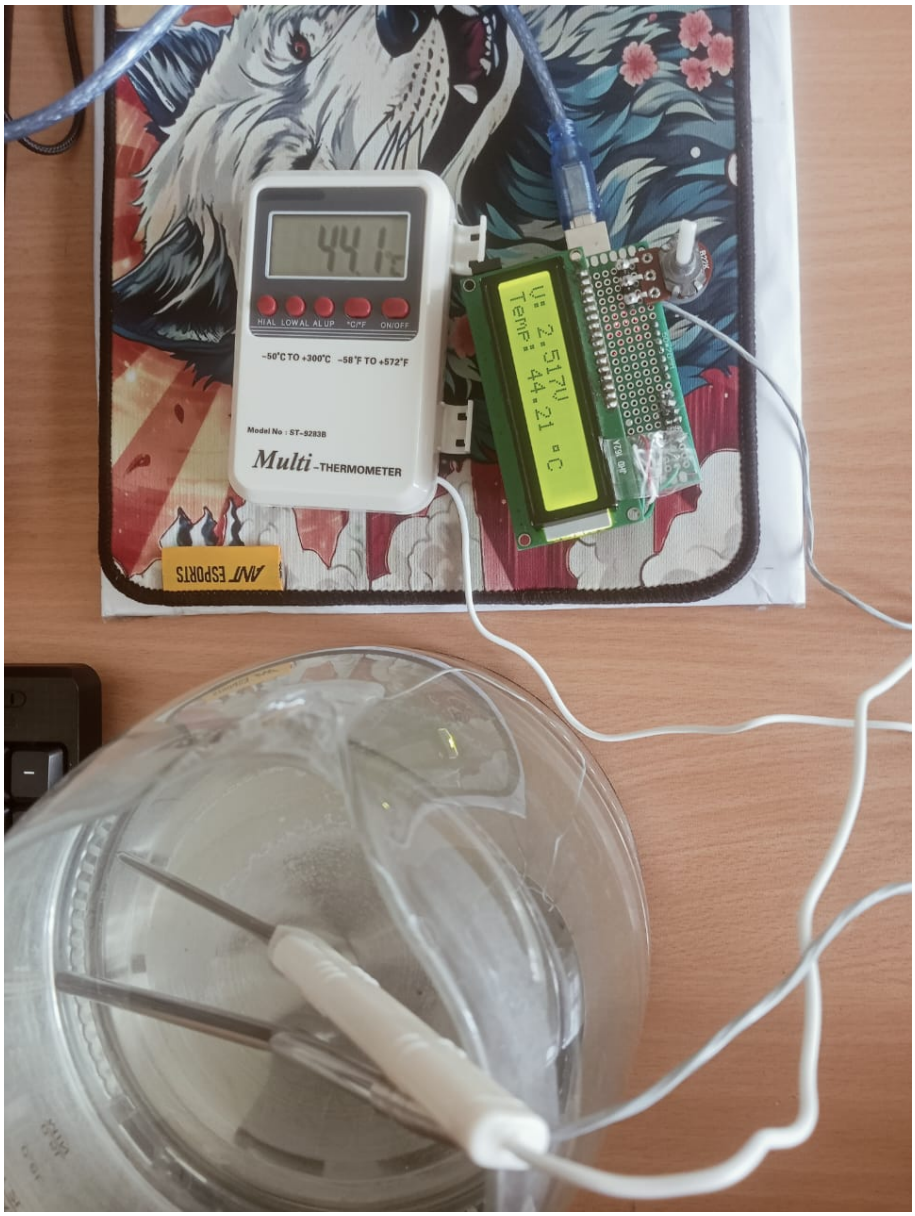


Figure 10: Project demonstration 2 alongside laboratory-grade thermometer.



Figure 11: Project demonstration 3 alongside laboratory-grade thermometer.

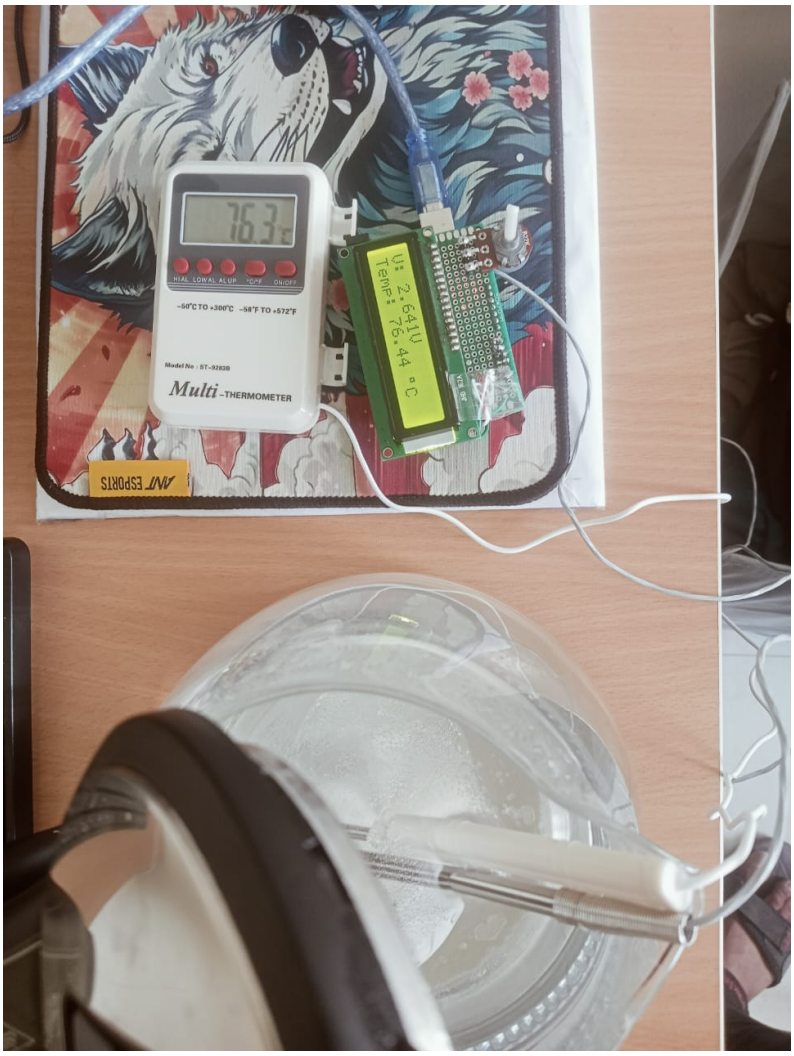


Figure 12: Project demonstration 4 alongside laboratory-grade thermometer.

9 Key Takeaways

This project helped us connect the theory of temperature-dependent resistance to a working electronic measurement system. We learned that temperature is not read directly by the Arduino: the sensor changes resistance, the circuit turns that change into a voltage, the ADC measures the voltage, and the code converts the measurement into a temperature estimate. Following this chain made the relationship between the physical sensor and the displayed value much more intuitive.

The project also taught us that debugging is a systematic process. Faulty jumper wires initially made us suspect the LCD or Arduino, reversed LCD data connections produced corrupted characters, and a solder bridge made the PT100 path appear to have zero resistance. In each case, careful inspection and multimeter measurements were more effective than changing multiple parts at once.

Most importantly, we learned that a reliable instrument is built through verification and calibration, not appearance alone. A polished enclosure and additional features cannot

compensate for an inaccurate measurement. For a thermometer intended for industrial use, we would rather complete tedious, repeatable calibration and minimise the measurement error than make half-hearted innovations in secondary aspects of the design. The priority is a dependable reading whose limitations are understood and whose performance has been checked against a reference.

Finally we have acheived a thermometer with a margin of error of 0.2 0.3 degrees as compared to the laboratory thermometer.

Project demonstration The complete demo of this project can be found at `https://youtube.com/shorts/N8T5c-BsDCI?feature=share`.